

Section Four

Ask Better Questions

CHAPTER 15

Seven Rules for Interview Questions That Result in Great Hires

by John Sullivan

Some of the long-held ideas about how to conduct interviews are no longer accurate. For example, there's no longer such thing as a surprise interview question. Candidates can prepare and video their practice interviews to the point where their responses are universally impressive, if not genuine or accurate.

It's not just surprise questions that are a thing of the past. Research at firms like Google has proven that "brainteaser questions" can contribute to a costly mis-hire, that having a candidate meet any more than four interviewers doesn't increase new-hire quality, and that for many jobs, factors like grades, test scores, and schools attended don't predict success in the position.

It's time to rethink your interview questions with a focus on work-related questions that are harder to fake an answer to.

Avoid easy-to-practice questions

If you work for a major corporation, most of the interview questions used by hiring managers at your firm are publicly posted on [Glassdoor.com](https://www.glassdoor.com)—along with recommended answers. So start with a clean slate of questions, and at the very least eliminate overused and easy-to-practice questions with a low predictive value, like "What are your greatest strengths and weaknesses?" and "Why are you the best candidate?" and "What's your dream job?" and "Where would you like to be in five years?"

Be wary of historical questions

Questions that require a candidate to describe how they performed in the past, also known as "behavioral interview questions" (e.g., "Tell me about a time when you led . . ."), are problematic in a fast-moving world where yesterday's approaches quickly become irrelevant. And according to research by professors Frank Schmidt and John Hunter, those questions predict success only 12% better than a coin flip.¹ Why? Because the way a candidate did something years ago at another firm may be the wrong answer today at this firm with its unique culture. Historical questions also allow a good storyteller to passionately describe how a problem was solved even though they only played a minor role in the solution.

Assess their ability to solve a problem

If you were hiring a chef, you would ask them to cook a meal. Taking a "job content" approach by having an applicant do some of the actual work is the best way to separate top candidates from average ones. Consider asking them to:

- **Identify problems on the job.** Say something like: “Please walk me through the steps of the process that you’ll use during your first weeks to identify the most important current problems or opportunities in your area.”
- **Solve a current problem.** The ability to solve current problems is often the number one predictive factor of job performance. Provide them with a description of an actual problem that they’ll face on their first day. Then ask them to walk you through the broad steps they would take to solve it. Prior to the interview, make a list of the essential steps. Deduct points if they omit important steps like gathering data, consulting with the team or customer, and identifying success metrics.
- **Identify the problems in your process.** Hand them a brief description of a flawed existing process related to their job. Ask them to examine the process and identify the top three areas where they predict serious problems are likely to occur. Prior to the interview, make a list of those pain points and flaws.

Evaluate whether they’re forward-looking

In fast-evolving environments, employees must anticipate the future. Consider asking these questions to assess how well a candidate can do that:

- **Outline your plan for this job.** The very best employees develop a plan before they begin a major project or new job. Ask them to outline the elements of their plan of action for their first three to six months. Have them highlight key components, including goals, whom they’ll consult with (by title), what data they’ll analyze, how they’ll communicate with their team, the metrics for assessing their plan’s success, etc.
- **Forecast the evolution of the job/industry.** Anticipating major shifts is critical. Ask them to forecast at least five ways that their job will likely evolve over the next three years as a result of changes in the business environment. New hires must also be able to anticipate changes in your industry. So consider asking candidates to project three to five major trends in your industry and then forecast how the top firms will need to change over the next few years to meet those trends.

Assess a candidate’s ability to learn, adapt, and innovate

If the job requires any of those factors, consider these questions:

- **Learning.** “Outline the steps you’d take to continuously learn and maintain your expert status in one important technical area.”
- **Agility.** “Outline the steps you’d take to adapt when a dramatic unexpected change occurs in either technology or customer expectations.”
- **Innovation.** “Outline the steps you’d take to increase innovation among your team to respond to increased competition or new technologies.”

Allocate time for selling

The bulk of the interview time should be allocated to assessing the candidate, but set aside time to excite and sell candidates on the job and your firm. Proactively ask, “What are the top factors that you’ll use to assess a job offer?” Then be sure to provide compelling information covering each “job acceptance factor.”

Interviews are tough to get right. But research has shown that carefully selecting questions and determining acceptable answers ahead of time will increase your chances of success.² Research also shows that most hiring decisions are made within 15 seconds, so you must consciously avoid any judgments until the interview is at least 50% completed.³

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Adapted from “7 Rules for Job Interview Questions That Result in Great Hires” on hbr.org, February 10, 2016 (product #H02NS8).

Notes

¹. Frank Schmidt and John Hunter, “The Validity and Utility of Selection Methods in Personnel Psychology,” *Psychological Bulletin* 124 (September 1998):262–274, doi: 10.1037/0033-2909.124.2.262.

². Lou Adler, “Esteemed Harvard Professor Blasts Current Hiring Practices,” LinkedIn, January 27, 2016, <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/esteemed-harvard-professor-blasts-current-hiring-practices-lou-adler/>.

³. Malcolm Gladwell, “The New-Boy Network,” *The New Yorker*, May 21, 2000, <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2000/05/29/the-new-boy-network>.

CHAPTER 16

Stop Asking Candidates the Wrong Questions

by Nilofer Merchant

I could tell right away from the tone of his voice that the VP of engineering wasn't happy. He practically growled at me. He had just finished interviewing a job candidate named Anand, who I had directed his way, and was calling me to say he was going to pass.

Just a few minutes earlier, Anand had called and raved about how well the interview had gone. He had interviewed for nearly a full day, meeting with different leaders across the organization, including, at the end of the day, the VP of engineering. I had helped this company build out a new “platform” strategy, which is why I was trying to identify the right candidates to work on it, and I thought Anand would be a great fit.

But the VP and Anand had strikingly different reports about their meeting. Anand said that he had asked far more questions than he usually did, asking for detailed and specific information on the strategy that helped him understand the complexity of the challenges the company was facing. He felt like he had held engaging, insightful conversations with everyone he met. In contrast, the VP told me that he found Anand's questions “super annoying.”

This isn't the first time I've heard a leader say that a perfectly qualified candidate is a “bad fit.” Candidates are too often screened out because they don't fit a particular pattern—one survey found as many as 75% of résumés don't make it past applicant tracking systems.¹ As I discussed the issue further with the VP, I learned that he thought that Anand had the right skills and experience but that he found Anand's questions annoying. He said: “He asked us a ton of questions that the team didn't have the answers to.” His assessment that Anand was a “bad fit” was really code for “I don't want to feel uncomfortable.”

Innovation requires not knowing long enough to learn new things. How can you build something new if you aren't okay with not already knowing the answer? The future is not created; it's co-created. Leaders need to build teams that can both *define* the right questions, and then *discover* new answers.

Instead of being annoyed by Anand's questions, the VP should've welcomed them—and asked Anand questions in turn. That is, of course, the value of an interview. An employer seeks to learn about the candidate's skills and relevant experiences. And a good candidate uses questions to learn about the role, the boss, and the company to assess whether it's the right job. Here are some types of questions the VP might've asked—and the ones you should ask—to avoid screening out a perfectly good candidate based on the wrong criteria.

Questions that uncover capabilities, not just experience

Are you asking questions that get to someone's *capabilities* or are you seeking confirming data that someone has done exactly what you have already scoped? Several years ago, a colleague asked if I'd review their job description for a social media "expert." Twitter had been around for maybe a year at this point and when I looked at the description, I just started laughing. The first line read "10 years of experience." Quite often, we use useless metrics to scope a job to do what has already been done. The upside of asking for years of experience is we get someone who has done what we need. The downside is we risk limiting what we can create next by doing what has already worked. Instead of asking, "Have you done x or y or z?" you want to ask, "How *would you approach* doing x or y or z?"

Unfortunately, an estimated 77% of all jobs (60% in the U.S. and 80% worldwide) require little to no creativity, decision-making, or independent judgment. But if you are working on innovation, you need someone who can *think with you*. And by focusing on capability over experience, you increase the chances you find that person.

Questions that assess whether they can co-create on a team

When I ask the teams I've worked with in the last 10 years why their last major strategic effort failed, they rarely mention that the team didn't get along. But they do say that there were cracks in the team—roles that weren't being filled—and that no one was able to step in to fill them. Because the world changes quickly, the work does too, and team members can't stay in their predetermined roles. Teams need to figure out new terrain together. You might ask candidates, "How would you handle a situation where it's become clear that there is a gap on your team?" Interviewees are often told to use "I" to get credit for work done, but "we" is probably a more realistic depiction of how work gets done. Then follow up to learn how they felt about the situation: Were they proud of catching the gap? Concerned that it existed in the first place? This will help you see if you are dealing with a team player or a know-it-all. You want to find people who can play together, filling in the gaps between predefined roles to get the work done.

Questions that uncover the kinds of things they love to work on

If you're hiring for innovation, you need to ask what this person authentically brings to work. Ideas, after all, are not invented and grown in a vacuum; they grow and evolve by connecting previously separate elements. Figuring out what people genuinely care about lets you put people together who don't have the same approaches but who want to reach the same goal. It's that connection where innovation happens. But people need to be united around a shared purpose and focused on something that has meaning to them. Ask candidates, "What did you find meaningful about that project?" "What does that particular success say about what matters to you?" People want to match their purpose to the organizations they work for. And it's your job as the leader to align that purpose so that seemingly disparate people can come together into an "us" headed in the same direction.

Too often, leaders screen out perfectly good candidates because they don't understand how to hire people for co-creative problem-solving. It's easy to forget that the job of a leader isn't to know all the answers but to create the conditions by which the entire team gets to learn and innovate.

In the end, the VP did hire Anand—and together they've realized the goals they set out to achieve.

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Adapted from “Stop Eliminating Perfectly Good Candidates by Asking Them the Wrong Questions” on hbr.org, March 22, 2019 (product #H04UHV).

NOTE

¹ Sanjoe Jose, “The Demise of Applicant Tracking Systems,” Talview, January 21, 2016, <https://blog.talview.com/en/demise-of-applicant-tracking-system>.

CHAPTER 17

Five Qualities to Look for in a New Hire

by Shanna Hocking

A great leader knows that their team members play a significant role in their and the organization's success. That's why understanding how to make a strong hire is an important skill for new managers to learn. Though you'll have a limited time with each candidate during the interview process, you can maximize that time by asking strategic questions to gain insights into their strengths and weaknesses. Ultimately, this can help you make more thoughtful hiring decisions.

As a team leader, hiring manager, and now coach, I've reviewed hundreds of résumés and successfully onboarded many employees who've gone on to thrive in their careers. Earlier on, I also made some hiring decisions that weren't right for either my teams or the candidates. Through all of this, I've learned a few valuable traits that new managers should consider when given the opportunity to make an addition to their teams.

Here are five traits to look for when interviewing for candidates who will benefit nearly every team, as well as the workplace culture.

Trait 1: Entrepreneurial Mindset

An entrepreneurial spirit isn't only for people who want to start their own business. Employees who demonstrate entrepreneurial qualities, such as being self-motivated and taking the initiative to create solutions to problems, can enhance any team. For example, an employee who sees challenges and believes they can solve them, or work through them, will help your organization achieve more than someone who gets easily frustrated by barriers. Plus, someone who naturally has, or who has done the work to develop, an entrepreneurial mindset is more likely to feel a sense of commitment and ownership to the organizational outcomes.¹

Particularly if you're in an industry where people hear "no" often (something common for the fundraising work I do), look for these employees—many of whom will see rejection as learning opportunities or chances to find a better approach or solution. This mindset will help them navigate the complexity of the role.

Interview questions to measure this skill

- Tell me about a time you pursued a work project that others didn't believe would be possible (or that others said had been tried before and wouldn't work).
- How have you improved a process or project in an organization?

Clues to look for in their answers

An entrepreneurial spirit, or a drive to solve challenges, isn't necessarily something people know they have. But it is reflected in how they develop plans, the decisions they make in stressful situations, and their willingness to try something again that previously didn't go as planned. The candidate may give examples about navigating a complex work environment or convey a sense of pride in the projects they contribute to. Look for cues that a candidate thinks creatively, is open to sharing ideas, adapts to unforeseen circumstances, and shows resilience.

Trait 2: Curiosity

Curiosity can be a cornerstone of building a strong organizational culture. Employees who demonstrate curiosity ask questions to learn more about the world and the people around them. They show willingness to experiment with new ideas and they bring a learning mindset to the role and workplace.

When employees feel they can challenge the status quo, it leads to more innovation and creativity.²

Curious employees want to learn the “why” that’s driving the actions of their employer, team members, customers, and industry, which will help your organization adapt and evolve.

Interview questions to measure this skill

- Tell me about a time you pursued a learning opportunity on your own (without being assigned or asked by your manager).
- What do you most enjoy learning about?

Clues to look for in their answers

Listen for how a candidate shares excitement about what they’ve learned recently or what they want to learn more about in the future. They might reference something they read or listened to that sparked their interest.

A candidate’s natural curiosity may also emerge when they follow up this answer to ask you about your own learning interests or how your organization supports learning, because they’ll want to find a manager who shares this commitment. If a candidate asks many questions during the interview, it can feel overwhelming to a hiring manager. But remember, the candidate is interviewing you as much as you’re interviewing them.

Trait 3: Leading from Where They Are

Employees often confuse title and authority with the ability to influence and lead. Everyone has the potential to serve as a leader if they approach leadership as the energy and purpose by which they lead themselves and serve others.

I often tell my clients that “leading from where they are” is one of the best ways to advance their careers and grow within an organization. Employees who find ways to work within organizational boundaries to create meaningful progress while leveraging their genuine relationships and expertise—even without being in a formal position of power—help to develop strong organizations.

Interview questions to measure this skill

- Tell me about a time you took initiative at work on something that benefited your whole team.

- Tell me about a time you influenced your colleagues to move something forward or try something new.

Clues to look for in their answers

Listen for how a candidate creates their own opportunities, raises their hand for projects, and supports their colleagues and the organizations' larger goals. For example, they may say they developed a new initiative, championed the adoption of a new process, or successfully led a committee of peers. A candidate who answers both the first and second question with clear examples demonstrates a pattern of leading from where they are.

Trait 4: Self-Awareness

Self-awareness at work looks like reflecting on your strengths, behaviors, and feelings to better understand how each area relates to your actions, your team, and your environment.

A self-aware employee proudly knows their strengths and what areas they need to develop further, which they actively work toward. This understanding of both their strengths and weaknesses contributes to a positive relationship with others. For example, when a team member feels confident in their own skills and abilities, and also respects their colleagues' strengths and perspectives, it can lead to better communication and collaboration—and ultimately a stronger team.

Interview questions to measure this skill

- What are your superpowers?
- What is a misperception people have about you at work?
- How would a colleague describe you?

Clues to look for in their answers

Most people believe they're self-aware, but they're likely not as aware as they think. Listen to how a candidate says a colleague would describe them, which reflects their understanding of their relationship to others.

A candidate who isn't highly self-aware might be confused by the suggestion that there are misconceptions about them in the workplace, for example. Remember that self-awareness is an ongoing process, so listen for the candidate to share what they're continuing to improve on to demonstrate their commitment to their personal growth.

Trait 5: Growth Potential

An employee with growth potential has ambition and drive, which benefits them and your organization. With ongoing support and resources, you can position the employee to strengthen your organization now and in the future. I'm not suggesting that you hire with the intention of retaining an employee forever, but do give thought to how a new hire will be able to grow within their role and your organization over time. Employees want to have a sense of what their future may look like in a new organization; as their boss, you should be committed to helping your team members reach their potential.

Ultimately, hiring for potential, rather than solely focusing on performance, can give you access to untapped talent and help you build a team of loyal employees who are grateful to work at a place that nurtures and invests in their professional development.

Interview questions to measure this skill

- How did you grow in your most recent role?
- What do you want to do differently/more of in your next role?

Clues to look for in their answers

A candidate with growth potential will provide examples of how they've improved themselves and their organization through their own initiative. They'll likely have clear ideas of what they'd like to learn or try in their new role in order to expand their experience and skill set. Review their résumé for additional insights. For example, an internal promotion recognizes that an employee continued to add value to an organization over time (as determined by people who evaluated their work outcomes).

Keep in mind, hiring isn't about finding the perfect person for the role. Perfect doesn't exist. Look for someone who has meaningfully contributed to other organizations and teams and who is excited to add value to your organization and team, too. Hiring well will become part of your legacy as a manager, and it's one of the ways you can directly and positively influence your organization's—and your new hire's—future.

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IDENTIFY—AND HIRE—LIFELONG LEARNERS

by Marc Zao-Sanders

Talent management has undergone a massive overhaul, accelerated by the Covid-19 pandemic. Working environments, business priorities, and new technologies have been adopted with prodigious urgency. Hiring and onboarding have become substantially remote activities. In January 2020—even before Covid appeared—the World Economic Forum called for a global reskilling revolution, and firms now require different skills of their workforces, including resilience, adaptability, digital, design, and interpersonal capabilities.^a

These changes have been a challenge for job candidates and employers alike. But I believe that there's a simple way to bring some much-needed clarity and guidance—one that adds value all the way along the employee life cycle, from hiring to managing performance.

The secret is to ask of people a simple question: *How do you learn?*

This is not about simplistic learning preferences (such as schedules and modalities) or broadly discredited learning styles (such as being a visual or aural learner).^b This is about an individual's personal system for updating, improving, and sharing her knowledge and skills. Does the job candidate you're considering have such a system? And, for that matter, do you?

This may be the most pertinent question one can ask of a current or future employee. An individual's future performance is just as much a function of high-caliber, systematic, intentional skills development as it is of past achievements and qualifications, the traditional fare of job interviews.^c And the capability and much of the value of a company is, in turn, a function of the collective skills of its workforce.

Lifelong learning is now roundly considered to be an economic imperative and “the only sustainable competitive advantage.”^d Job candidates and employees who consider, update, and improve their skills are the high performers, especially over the longer term. Pressing ourselves on the question of how we learn brings a hard, pragmatic edge to the important but nebulous notion of growth mindset.

Let's consider the question's application to a key stage of the employee lifecycle: hiring.

Hiring and Getting Hired

Suppose the question were asked by default during the screening process. Convincing answers would indicate high levels of curiosity, organization, and method.

As a hiring manager:

- **Take care to be inclusive and open-minded about what counts as learning.** This is partly to be able to appreciate cultural and personal differences. It's also to recognize that there is a dizzying proliferation of content from which one can learn: courses, books, people, poems, performance support tools, songs, films, conversations, observations, reflections, memories, and more.^e How does the candidate go about making sense of all of this? How do they face up to content overload? How do they select what's most relevant and then slice, dice, and digest it in a way that improves their feeling of fulfillment and level of performance over the long term?
- **Ask the candidate about something they've recently learned** and how they could apply it in the role for which you are considering them.
- **Be prepared to have the same question be asked of you.** Show an awareness of the skills deemed to be of particularly high value at the firm—this is typically a list of 20 to 100 skills, behaviors, and values, defined with care.

^a Saadia Zahidi, “We Need A Global Reskilling Revolution—Here's Why,” World Economic Forum, January 22, 2020, <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2020/01/reskilling-revolution-jobs-future-skills/>

^b Olga Khazan, “The Myth of ‘Learning Styles,’” *The Atlantic*, April 11, 2018, <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2018/04/the-myth-of-learning-styles/557687/>.

^c Daniel Pachtod and Michael Park, “‘Look for Skills, Not Credentials’: Beth Cobert on Tapping Into US Talent,” *mckinsey.com*, February 26, 2021, <https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/look-for-skills-not-credentials-beth-cobert-on-tapping-into-us-talent?cid=other-eml-alt-mip-mck&hdpid=1662ed5f-e61e-4253-bd72-4451dbbcc783&hctky=9621023&hlkid=dc8941dda7d541509abe0c5f5d0d9998>.

^d “Lifelong Learning Is Becoming an Economic Imperative,” *The Economist*, January 12, 2017, <https://www.economist.com/special-report/2017/01/12/lifelong-learning-is-becoming-an-economic-imperative>; Arie de Geus, “Planning as Learning,” *Harvard Business Review*, March 1988, <https://hbr.org/1988/03/planning-as-learning>.

^e Marc Zao-Sanders, “Filter!,” *Filtered* blog, accessed August 26, 2024, <https://learn.filtered.com/thoughts/filter>.

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NOTES

1. Jon L. Pierce, Tatiana Kostova, and Kurt T. Dirks, "Toward a Theory of Psychological Ownership in Organizations," *Academy of Management Review* 26, no. 2 (2001): 298–310, <https://doi.org/10.2307/259124>.

2. Siyuan Wang, "The Curvilinear Relationship Between Dissatisfaction with the Status Quo and Innovative Behavior," *Frontiers in Psychology* 13 (2022), doi.10.3389/fpsyg.2022.849586.

CHAPTER 18

Evaluate Responses to Common Interview Questions

by Xena Wang

You've received a great response to the job you've posted. You've worked with HR to narrow your list of potential candidates and schedule interviews. You've done all your prep work, and you have your list of questions prepared. How will you measure the responses the candidates provide? What does a "good" answer to some of the most common interview questions look like?

Good vs. Bad Answers

As a first step, it's useful to understand what components differentiate a good and bad answer to common interview questions.

A good answer includes narratives or examples that are:

- Specific, clear, and self-aware
- Relatively recent
- Related to the core competencies highlighted in the job description

A bad answer includes narratives or examples that are:

- Too personal, unprofessional, or irrelevant
- Overly negative
- A poor reflection on your character or skills

With this information in mind, here are some things to look for in candidates' responses to some of the common questions you might pose.

Question #1: Why are you interested in this role?

Perhaps this role is the perfect next step in the candidate's career trajectory, or maybe it's a lateral move that has better benefits. It could be a back-up role the candidate applied to because the job market is competitive, or a stretch position they weren't expecting to be called in for. Whatever the circumstance, you'll want the candidate to focus their answer on two things:

- Specific aspects of the role that they find compelling and why. (How does the role align with their career goals?)
- The value they would bring to the team or organization through this role. (What can they offer you, given their unique skills and background experience?)

Scenario

A candidate works at a tech company as a programmer, but they want to pivot into a primarily client-facing role. The candidate already has a deep understanding of technological developments and coding. They want a job that combines their expertise and provides increased opportunities to engage with the software's users. To achieve this, they are interviewing for a sales associate position at a prominent software company.

Bad answer: I saw that the position was open, and I wanted to apply because I'm not fulfilled in my current job. I spend most of my time working on the computer, but I want to travel more and talk to people. Based on the job description, I think this role could be interesting since it involves more face-to-face interaction with clients.

This is a bad response because it's vague. It focuses solely on what the candidate wants without explaining *why* interacting with customers is important to them or how it fits into their current career goals. It also fails to explain the value they would add as a new hire.

Good answer: I'm excited for this role because I've been looking to build more in-person client relationships. In my current role, I've developed strong technical skills, and I see this as an opportunity to use my expertise to help our customers better understand our products and choose the ones that best fit their needs.

I see that this job requires 50% travel or more, which excites me as I'm someone who enjoys experiencing new environments and people, but also having a home base I can return to.

Right now, I'm mostly working independently at my computer. I've still managed to cultivate strong relationships with various clients in the past couple of years, but I would thrive on the opportunity to travel and meet them face-to-face. Being in-person would also help me better understand their pain points and how to solve them. When it comes to problem solving, I think communication is much easier for both parties in-person than over a screen when possible.

Unlike the bad response, the candidate in this example focuses on the positive aspects of their present role while also explaining the opportunities the new role would provide them. In addition, they explain how those opportunities better align with their current goals and how their contributions would benefit the company and its clientele.

Question #2: Tell me about a time when you worked well as part of a team

Here you're looking for the candidate to showcase transferable soft skills like collaboration, adaptability, and communication. These are key skills that would be beneficial in nearly all work environments and teams. This question can also be an opportunity for the candidate to showcase their leadership expertise.

Scenario

A college senior is preparing for their job search before graduation. They aren't sure what industry they want to pursue yet, but they know they enjoy—and are good at—leading teams. The senior is interviewing for an event planner role at a local nonprofit that hosts fundraisers and community programs.

Bad answer: Last semester, I had a group project for a history class presentation. I took the lead by telling everyone to take one part and to meet back again in two weeks. I did my work, my classmates did theirs, and we grouped it all together at the end. Our professor said we had a great presentation.

This response at least underscores teamwork since the group accomplished their assignment. However, it lacks emphasis on three things: effective communication (ordering people to take part rather than discussing work division), collaboration (everyone only doing their part and bringing it together in the end), and specificity (role responsibilities and project road map).

Good answer: Last semester, we had a four-person group project for our history class. My classmates were unsure who would tackle which part, so I took action and delegated the tasks: one each for research, outline, graphics, and speaking.

Since public speaking is my strength, I offered to present on behalf of the group. The project was due in two weeks, so I scheduled a couple of midweek check-ins—both for accountability and to make sure that our content was on the right track.

There was an instance where a team member didn't get the outline by our check-in time, which delayed the graphics creation. I spoke with the individual to let them know that our grade relied on all of us working together and supporting each other. They understood where I was coming from and submitted their outline the next day.

Ultimately, we finished the project on time—and our professor said it was one of the best presentations in recent years!

This response shows how the candidate took initiative by discussing and assigning upcoming tasks. It also shows how the candidate worked well in a team setting: first, by noticing friction with a member neglecting their assignment; then, by speaking with the person and communicating the group's shared responsibilities in order to resolve the issue. As a bonus, it also reflects how the candidate's collaborative leadership led to a successful outcome.

Question #3: Have you ever had difficulty working with a manager or other team members?

When the candidate answers this question, you'll be listening to hear if they remain respectful and professional—even if they worked with a nightmare manager or on a dysfunctional teams. Everyone has disagreements at times—including the highest-performing teams—but that doesn't mean people can't work together toward a common goal.

Be wary of candidates who criticize, blame, or complain. You're looking for the candidate to stay neutral and stick to the facts.

Scenario

A midlevel employee is excited about a senior learning and development role at a rival pharmaceutical company. This new position encompasses designing and implementing programs from interns to the C-suite. On their own, the employee has already created sessions on onboarding, upskilling, and career growth. However, this senior L&D job requires collaborative input from multiple individuals across departments.

Bad answer: Yes. I had a disagreement with a colleague who wanted things done her way. Basically, I planned to run a career-building webinar for our summer interns. I took the initiative to reach out to one of our partners with HR expertise to participate, but this colleague was upset that I didn't consult her first since she's the liaison for this person.

I told her I was trying to streamline the requests so we could launch the webinar quickly. The colleague didn't see my perspective and thought I was upstaging her. She told me that moving forward, I'd have check in with her before contacting this HR partner.

Anyway, I've since organized nine professional development webinars. I've also come up with creative methods that don't involve waiting for their approval so we can launch these events faster.

While the candidate didn't explicitly belittle their colleague, their negative tone suggests that they think the colleague overreacted in the situation. Although this answer does highlight their accomplishments, it ultimately demonstrates how they don't take accountability or collaborate to find solutions.

Good answer: I had a misunderstanding with a teammate regarding project communication. I wanted to ask one of our partners with HR expertise to participate in a career-building webinar for our summer interns. However, I overlooked informing my teammate, who was the liaison for this colleague, and she felt like I was trying to overshadow her role.

Instead of letting this misinterpretation escalate, I initiated a private conversation with her to - communicate my intentions. I apologized for not looping her in before contacting our HR partner and reassured her that moving forward, I would first check in with her about project tasks.

Together, we found a compromise that strengthened our working relationship and responsibilities. She's continued to be a great help in setting up similar professional development webinars.

A good response like this reflects the candidate's ability to handle challenging people and situations constructively. This answer also states the obstacles, the efforts made trying to resolve them, and the results.

Question #4: Tell me about a time you failed

This feels like a trick question—and to some extent, it is. You want the candidate to share an experience introducing a minor lapse in judgment and how they learned and improved from it. Red flags include an example that's too serious (such as a mistake that got the candidate fired) or that's related to your role's core competencies. The ideal answer will explain the situation, consequences, and solution.

Scenario

A consultant with two years of experience is grateful to have learned about various industries in their job. Now, they wish to focus solely on public policy analysis. Consulting has made them comfortable with high-pressure, fast-paced environments, and they are well prepared to transition into similar settings. Furthermore, the candidate also finds overlaps between this job opportunity and their consulting history: collaborating with several stakeholders to identify and solve problems—all while operating under strict timelines.

Bad answer: I didn't submit a report on time for a critical client presentation, which impacted the timeline and reflected poorly on our team. My manager was upset since she knows I'm not normally like that. I apologized to her, but we did end up losing the client.

This is a bad answer because while it addresses the failure, it doesn't acknowledge how the candidate learned from their mistake. It only touches on the issue and aftermath.

Good answer: During a particularly hectic work period, I didn't submit a report on time for a client presentation. This impacted the project timeline and our team's reputation. My manager was upset since this lapse was uncharacteristic of my usual behavior. I then took immediate responsibility by personally apologizing to my manager, my colleagues, and especially the clients.

The clients were understandably frustrated but appreciated my accountability. After that event, I implemented new strategies for myself to improve time management skills and communication with teammates when I needed support to meet deadlines. I also helped our team develop a contingency reference PDF that will help prevent similar situations in the future.

This response shows that we all make mistakes at work (they're inevitable), but what we do after messing up matters more. It shows how the candidate handled the mistake, which reveals their integrity and resilience in difficult circumstances. Those are the kind of people that make up strong teams.

Interviews are meaningful opportunities to explore a candidate's experience, mindset, and skills. As you consider how these qualities align with the role and your organization, listen with these pointers—and an open mind.

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